SPAN 7559 | Latin American Digital Humanities

TuTh 11-12:15 | Alderman 317 | Spring 2017
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From the colonial period to the present day, the *Popol Vuh*, sometimes called the Maya book of creation, has been translated, edited, paraphrased, and glossed in more than 25 languages. WorldCat suggests that there are over 1,200 known editions of the work, published in verse, scholarly editions, and illustrated volumes. In addition to differences in form and genre, Spanish-language volumes offer very different interpretations of the K'iche' source text. The opening line of Adrián Recinos's translation is, "Este es el principio de las antiguas historias de este lugar llamado Quiché," while Emilio Abreu Gómez renders it as, "Entonces no había ni gente, ni animales, ni árboles, ni piedras, ni nada." Readers' interpretations of the text, and of Maya cultural and spiritual traditions conveyed in translation, thus depend upon the editions they consult, and these editions vary widely.

In this class, we will design a thematic research collection of the *Popol Vuh*, housed at the Newberry Library and digitally hosted by the Ohio State University Library. By encoding the manuscript with tools that show the graphic and narrative complexity of the *Popol Vuh*, this project will allow readers to engage deeply with questions of historical, spiritual, and cultural translation. Such tools will ideally include images (glyphs, vases, figures from codices), maps, and alternative translations. Primary readings include translations and editions of the *Popol Vuh*; secondary sources will address key topics in Classic and Post-Classic Maya Studies (archaeology, art history, linguistics), as well as critical paradigms in DH scholarship (evaluation, methodology, pedagogy).

On seminar days (Tuesdays, led by professor Bigelow), we will analyze primary and secondary readings and identify features we want to encode in our digital critical edition. On studio days (Thursdays, led by professor Alvarado), we will learn how to encode textual variants and graphic forms using Drupal software. We will work in small teams (2-3 people) to encode a section of the manuscript (about 6 folios per person). In this way, we'll build skills in literary/translation analysis and DH research, thinking critically about the problems that DH platforms do and do not resolve in Latin American, Mesoamerican, and Indigenous Studies.

This course is offered in the spring of 2017 so that students can present work at the 2018 DH conference in Mexico City, the first time that the conference will be held in Latin America.

Primary readings

Adrián Recinos, trans. *Popol Vuh: Las antiguas historias del Quiché* (México: Fondo de Cultura Económica, 2012). ISBN 978-968-16-0327-4.
Emilio Abreu Gómez, trans. *Popol Vuh: Antiguas leyendas del Quiché* (México: Fondo de Cultura Económica, 2010). ISBN 978-607-16-0462-0.
Dennis Tedlock, trans. *Popol Vuh: The Definitive Edition of the Mayan Book of the Dawn of Life and the Glories of Gods and Kings* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 1996). ISBN 978-068-48-1845-0.

Allen J. Christenson, trans. *Popol Vuh: Literal Poetic Version* (Norman: University of Oklahoma Press, 2008). ISBN 978-0-8061-3841-1 and *Popol Vuh: The Sacred Book of the Maya* (Norman: University of Oklahoma Press, 2007). ISBN 978-0-8061-3839-8.

Schedule of readings and studios

Thursday, January 19: Orientation
Pre-distributed readings:
María Rosenda de la Cruz Vázquez, "La tradición literaria, el conocimiento de la educación y cultura indígena", *Oralidad y escritura: Experiencias desde la literatura indígena*, ed. Luz María Lepe Lira (Universidad de Michoacán, 2016), 137-152.
Matthew Kirschenbaum, "What is Digital Humanities and What's It Doing in English Departments?" pp. 3-11, and Rafael Alvarado, "The Digital Humanities Situation," pp. 50-55, in *Debates in the Digital Humanities*, ed. Matthew K. Gold (Minnesota UP, 2012).

Tuesday, January 24: Seminar 1
Core: Core Recinos, libro I (pp. 23-48); Gómez, "Prólogo" y "Los abuelos" (pp. 19-52)
Background (everyone): Michael Coe and Stephen Houston, *The Maya*, pp. 7-32
Methodological/theoretical (discussion leader: Catherine Addington):
Néstor Quiroa, "The Popol Vuh and the Dominican Religious Extirpation in Highland Guatemala: Prologues and Annotations of Fr. Francisco Ximénez," *The Americas*, 67.4 (2011), 467-494.

Thursday, January 26: Studio 1 / Project Planning
Readings: Unsworth, 2005, "Thematic Research Collections"; Palmer, 2005, "Thematic Research Collections."
Topics: Overview and execution of project planning process. Review of concept of and other thematic research collections, digital critical editions, and variora to frame the project. Discussion of concept of remediation. Presentation of Github as space for organizing project tasks, milestones, and resources.

Tuesday, January 31: Seminar 2
Core: Recinos, libro II (pp. 49-102); Gómez, "Los abuelos" (pp. 53-72);
Background (everyone): Michael Coe and Stephen Houston, *The Maya*, 41-92.
Methodological/theoretical (discussion leader: **Karina A. Baptista**):
Nathan C. Henne, "Untranslation: The *Popol Wuj* and Comparative Methodology," *CR: The New Centennial Review* 12.2 (2012), 107-149.

Thursday, February 2: Studio 2 / Setting Things Up
Reading: A Gentle Introduction to XML.
Topics: Installation of and introduction to assemblage of tools. Create accounts in and log into course Github repository. Overview of Github and follow-up of planning and communication processes. Overview of Oxygen, XML, and creation of first documents in repository.

Tuesday, February 7: Seminar 3
Core: Recinos, libro III (pp. 103-126); Gómez, "Los magos" (pp. 75-118);
Background (everyone): Tomás Pérez Suárez, "Las lenguas mayas: historia y diversidad", *Revista Digital Universitaria* (UNAM) 5.7 (2004): 2-11.
Methodological/theoretical (discussion leader: _____):
Enrique Florescano, "Los paradigmas mesoamericanos que unificaron la reconstrucción del pasado: el mito de la creación del cosmos; la fundación del reino maravilloso (Tollán), y Quetzalcóatl, el creador de estados y dinastías", *Historia mexicana* 52.2 (2002): 309-359.

Thursday, February 9: Studio 3 / Begin Text Encoding
Reading: Refining Our Notion of What Text Really Is.
Topics: Overview of digitized primary sources available. Discussion of which materials to encode. Overview of text encoding as based on a model of the text and as remediation across media ecologies. Discussion of how to represent texts, intertextuality, annotations, and other layers in XML. Document types and content models. Students acquire texts in raw form and begin the process of encoding them in basic XML TEI.

Tuesday, February 14: Seminar 4
Core: Recinos, libro IV (pp. 127-162); Gómez, "Los magos" (pp. 119-169).
Background (everyone): Michael Coe and Stephen Houston, *The Maya*, 224-278/
Methodological/theoretical (discussion leader: **Benjamín Romero Salado**):
Ann González, "The *Popol Vuh* for Children: Explicit and Implicit Ideological Agendas," *Children's Literature Association Quarterly*, 39.2 (2014), 216-233 **AND/OR** Sue Giffard, "Expanding Horizons and Encouraging New Perspectives Through Myths: Experiments in Interactive Storytelling in an Elementary School Library," *Knowledge Quest* 44.3 (2016): 18-27.

Thursday, February 16: Studio 4 / Continue Text Encoding
Continue encoding primary sources. Begin process of annotating texts for named entities.

Tuesday, February 21: Seminar 5
Core: Tedlock, Introduction (pp. 21-60) and part I (pp. 63-74); Christenson (prose), "Preamble-Pride of 7 Macaw" (pp. 59-93). **Project proposal due.**

Thursday, February 23: Studio 5 / Continue Text Annotation
Continue annotating texts for named entities.

Tuesday, February 28: Seminar 6
Core: Tedlock, part II (pp. 77-88); Christenson (prose), "Fall of 7 Macaw-Defeat of Cabracan" (94-112).
Background (everyone): Simon Martin and Nikolas Grube, *Chronicle of the Maya Kings and Queens*, 6-21, 128-133.
Methodological/theoretical (discussion leader: **Matthew Richey**):
Dora Luz Cobián, *Génesis y evolución de la figura femenina en el Popol Vuh* (Plaza y Valdés, 1999): 11-15 and 130-145.

Thursday, March 2: Studio 6 / Review of Encoding and Annotation Work
Readings: Descola, 2006, Beyond Nature and Culture.
Continue process of encoding texts. Discussion of ontology. Lecture notes.

SPRING BREAK

Tuesday, March 14: Seminar 7
~~**Core**: Tedlock, part III (pp. 91-142); Christenson (prose), "Father of Hunahupu-Apotheosis" (pp. 112-191).~~
Background (everyone): Martha J. Macri and Matthew G. Looper, *The New Catalog of Maya Hieroglyphs*, vol. I, pp. 4-17
Methodological/theoretical (discussion leader: **Will Norton**):
Peter L. Schillingsburg, *From Gutenberg to Google* (Cambridge UP, 2006), 1-39.
Project updates: copyright policies (summary of meeting with Brandon Butler, UVa Library); collaborative practices (discuss email from José Yac Noj and partnership with Academia de Lenguas Mayas de Guatemala; review Allison's email to Sam Colop's family).
Review plan for the second half of the term.

Thursday, March 16: Studio 7 / Building Out the Ontology and Project Related Data

Tuesday, March 21: Seminar 8
~~**Core**: Tedlock, part IV (pp. 145-175); Christenson (prose), "Creation of Humanity-The Nations are Defeated" (pp. 192-252);~~
Background (everyone): William Foley, *Anthropological Linguistics*, 68-73 ("Metaphors of the Body") and 188-191 ("Models, Metaphors, and Grammatical Categories").
Methodological/theoretical (discussion leader: _____Rachel Gardella_____):
Barbara Herrnstein Smith, "What was 'Close Reading'? A Century of Method in Literary Studies" (talk delivered at Columbia University, NYC, on 6 May 2015 and posted to academia.edu thereafter)
Project updates: Catherine Addington (1r-4v), Rafael Alvarado (5r-11v), Karina Baptista (12r-15v).

Thursday, March 23: Studio 8 / Representing the Cosmovision
Project updates: Allison Bigelow (16r-22v), Nicole Bonino (23r-27v), Matthew Richey (48r-51v)

Tuesday, March 28: Seminar 9
~~**Core**: Tedlock, part V (pp. 179-198); Christenson (prose), "Deaths of the 4 Progenitors-end" (pp. 253-305);~~
Background (everyone): Stephen Houston, *The Life Within: Classic Maya and the Matter of Permanence*, pp. 1-29
Methodological/theoretical (discussion leader: __**NICOLE**_____):
Tara McPherson, "Why are the Digital Humanities So White? or Thinking the Histories of Race and Computation," *Debates in DH*, Gold ed., 139-160. AND/OR Amy E. Earhart, "Can Information Be Unfettered? Race and the New Digital Humanities Canon," *Debates in DH*, Gold ed., 309-318.

Guest speaker: Jeremy Sabloff, "Beyond Ancient Maya Temples, Palaces, and Tombs: How Maya Archaeologists Discovered the 99% Through the Study of Pre-Columbian Settlement Patterns"

Abstract: Current scholarly understandings of Pre-Columbian Maya civilization are quite different from the traditional model of ancient Maya civilization that dominated the field of Maya studies until recently and still dominates public perception of the ancient Maya. In part, this new view is due to both the significant increase in archaeological studies in the Maya area in the past few decades and the decipherment of Maya hieroglyphic texts, which have provided new insights into Maya history. However, much of the change is due to the introduction and rapid spread of settlement pattern studies more than a half a century ago. This lecture examines the major impact of the methodology of settlement pattern research on Maya archaeology and how such studies have moved archaeological studies away from their concentration on the ruling elites to a broader, more realistic approach that looks at elites and commoners alike.

Thursday, March 30: Studio 9 / Narrative Models
Project updates: Rachel Gardella (32r-35v), Michelet McClean (36r-39v), Will Norton (40r-43v)

Tuesday, April 4: Seminar 10
~~**Core**: Christenson (poetry), pp. 13-70;~~ (Allison in Buenos Aires – skype)
Background (everyone): Fidencio Briceño Chel, "La maya, lo maya, un maya: Lengua, cultura e identidad de un pueblo" (2010, ponencia presentada en el Festival de la Mayanidad, Universidad Autónoma de Yucatán, 26-27 agosto de 2010).
Methodological/theoretical (discussion leader: ____**María**_____):
Matthew Jockers, *Macroanalysis: Digital Methods & Literary History*, pp. 3-32
Project updates: Dave Prine (44r-47v), Benjamín Romero (52r-55v), María Esparza (28r-31v)

Thursday, April 6: Studio 10: Extracting Cultural Networks

Tuesday, April 11: Seminar 11
~~**Core**: Christenson (poetry), pp. 71-128~~
Methodological/theoretical (everyone): Alexander Reid, "Graduate Education and the Ethics of the Digital Humanities," *Debates in DH*, Gold ed., 350-367.

Thursday, April 13: Studio 11: Analytics and Visualization

Tuesday, April 18: Seminar 12
~~**Core**: Christenson (poetry), pp. 129-185~~
Methodological/theoretical (everyone): Julia Flanders, "Time, Labor, and 'Alternate Careers' in Digital Humanities Knowledge Work," *Debates in DH*, Gold ed., 292-308.

Thursday, April 20: Studio 12 / Project Work

Tuesday, April 25: Seminar 13
~~**Core**: Christenson (poetry), pp. 186-262~~

Methodological/theoretical (everyone): Cathy Davidson, "Humanities 2.0: Promise, Perils, Predictions," *Debates in DH*, Gold ed., 476-489.

Thursday, April 27: Studio 13 / Project Work
Guest speaker: Davide Domenici (Bologna). "Materiality of color in Mesoamerican codices"

Abstract: This presentation will synthesize the results of non-destructive chemical analysis that we made on a series of precolumbian manuscripts held in European museums. It will also explain our attempts to interpret them in cultural and historical terms, both regarding the identification of Pre-Columbian scribal schools and emic perception of the materiality of the manuscripts. In other words, this talk touches the fields of research on museum collections and of Mesoamerican art history.

Offered in conjunction with the Institute of Humanities and Global Cultures and Mellon Indigenous Arts Initiative. Thanks to Debjani Ganguly, Ricardo Padrón, and Adriana Greci Green for thinking of us.

Tuesday, May 2: Course Conclusions (Allison en route from Lima -- skype)
Methodological/theoretical (everyone): Ernesto Priani Saisó, "Finding Support for Disruption: Developing a Digital Humanities Project in Mexico." *ASLib Proceedings* 64.1 (2012): 97-103 **AND** Benjamin Fraser and Christine Henseler, "The Future of Hispanic Studies: An Interactive Conversation with Journal Editors," *Arizona Journal of Hispanic Cultural Studies*, 18.1 (2014), 135-180 (166-172 only).

Evaluation:

Project: 50%
Participation 50%

Project:

1. Late February: proposal identifying 2 or 3 sections or themes that you would like to work on. These can be temporal-spatial (the introduction, transitions from the underground to the world above), motif-based (color terms, place names, family relationships, plants, material cultures/goods represented through words), or disciplinary-methodological (linguistic evidence, graphic elements, correlations to known historical events). Your proposal should mention what you hope to learn, why you're drawn to these sections or themes, and what primary and secondary sources you'll use for references. You should also mention what challenges you anticipate and how you plan to respond to them. You may write in English or Spanish, as you prefer.

2. March-April: evidence of progress in technologies used.

3. May: final project of 4-6 annotated folios of the *Popol Vuh* (Ximénez manuscript); sectional/thematic container in Drupal; 3-4 page letter of reflection identifying what you learned, what you did well, and what you wish you had done differently.

You're encouraged to frame this letter as a project report that you might present at the DH conference in 2018. In that case, please include a 250-word abstract that we'll help you revise before submission.

Project updates: based on near-consensus from the doodle poll, we'll focus on the project for the second half of the semester. Instead of discussing variant translations, please prepare to talk about your section of the text for 15 minutes.

You should tell us: 1) what challenges you faced with your folios, 2) what you were able to resolve, and 3) what you need help with or would like to debate. You might also want to signal something that a classmate is working on, if it appears in your section (e.g., "Oye, Matthew, tengo una cita interesante en cuanto a la comida. Debes consultar el folio 22.")

Here's an example of something you might present: Hey y'all, Dora Luz Cobián argues that half of the text features female protagonists. Do we agree? How should we represent that? If we mark up "la vieja" as "Xmucane," are we highlighting women's roles in the original text, or are we imposing a modern feminist interpretation? Here's what I did for now. What do you think?

These technical questions are intellectual and interpretative questions that get to the heart of literary analysis: structures of power as they are organized through language. Other technical questions, such as how to represent marginal notes, different handwriting, and holes in the manuscript, invite us to consider the historical or even archaeological nature of the *Popol Vuh*.

Participation:

1. Weekly attendance in seminar and studio; thoughtful contributions to discussion

2. Serve as discussion leader for 1 methodological/theoretical source. When it's your turn, please write a 1-page summary (Spanish or English) of the article's research intervention, methods, and evidence, and identify 2-3 questions you'd like the group to consider. Please post your handout to collab by 5 pm on Monday. Over the semester, we'll amass about 15 pages of reading guides that you can cite in your annotations, conference papers, grant proposals, or research projects.

3. 3 close readings of variant translations (1-2 pages each, written in Spanish or English). These short assignments are designed for you to practice the close reading skills that are the hallmark of comparative literary analysis. A typical conference paper is 8-10 pages (depending on how quickly or slowly you read); by the end of the semester, you will have a wide variety of secondary sources (history, anthropology, linguistics, literature) in which to situate your own critical interpretation.

Resources and ideas for conference papers & research projects:

Karen Bassie Sweet, *Maya Sacred Geography and the Creator Deities* (mapping the spirit world)
Scott A. J. Johnson, *Translating Maya Hieroglyphs* (graphic writing systems: glyphs to emojis)
Comparisons between *PV* and s. XX-contemporary adaptations (e.g., Asturias, Lezama Lima)
Neatline/Praxis and Mayan concepts of time: http://praxis.scholarslab.org/
Florescano: ¿hubo una cultura mesoamericana? (Can DH scholarship help answer the question?)
Pedro Carrasco: mito e historia en la literatura mesoamericana (ítem)

Honor Code:

This class takes seriously the University of Virginia's commitment to a scholarly community of trust. This means that we honor each other's right to a rigorous education, and that we pledge not to lie, cheat, or steal to or from each other. This class also supports collaborative work, because language, literature, and writing are fundamentally social, human enterprises. We therefore encourage you to work together, challenging each other to think critically and respectfully disagree with each other's interpretations of dense and difficult texts. You are also encouraged to take advantage of the rich resources that this campus has to offer – visit us in office hours, consult with research librarians in Alderman, Clemmons, and Special Collections, and learn from your peers in and outside of the classroom. All written work – whether pen to paper or finger to keyboard – will be your own, because we want to see your thoughts and help you to revise your expression of them.

Student Safety:

The Department of Spanish, Italian, and Portuguese aims to provide a safe space for our students, and to create the kind of learning environment in which you do your best work. If you are feeling overwhelmed, stressed, or isolated, there are many individuals here who are ready and wanting to help. If you wish, you can make an appointment with the Office of the Dean of Students to speak in private (http://www.virginia.edu/deanofstudents/). This includes students who are struggling with immigration issues; your confidentiality will be respected.

Alternatively, the University of Virginia has made other resources available to you. The Student Health Center offers Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS) for students. Call 434.243.5150 to schedule an appointment, or 434.972.7004 for after hours and weekend crisis assistance. If you prefer to speak anonymously and confidentially by phone, Madison House's HELP Line is available 24/7, at 434.295.8255.

If you or someone you know is struggling with gender, sexual, or domestic violence, please do not stay silent. The campus community has many resources for you and your friends, including me, as your professor. Your instructors are designated as responsible employees, which means that we must report crimes of sexual abuse or violence that are shared with us.

The university also has confidential employees who are not required to report. For a comprehensive list of services and resources, visit the UVA Sexual Violence Education and Resources webpage, http://www.virginia.edu/sexualviolence/. Additionally, you can contact the Office of the Dean of Students, Sexual Assault Resource Agency (SARA), Shelter for Help in Emergency (SHE), and UVA Women's Center. Finally, you can contact the Director of Sexual and Domestic Violence Services at 434.982.2774 for more information.

Trigger Warnings:

The colonial period, like all moments of human history and life, is marked by events that inspire us and bring us pain. We will read authors who address experiences that are rooted in suffering and abuse, including violence and rape. Some of their work is graphic, because they are dealing with powerful issues – as is the veteran or survivor of sexual abuse who is sitting next to you. You are expected to read these stories critically and engage thoughtfully with them. It is okay if you need to step out of class for a moment. It is also important that you find support in resources on campus, especially counselors, teachers, and friends. Please see above for a list of resources.